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Reshaping the Gap: Technology as an Opportunity vs. Widening Inequality

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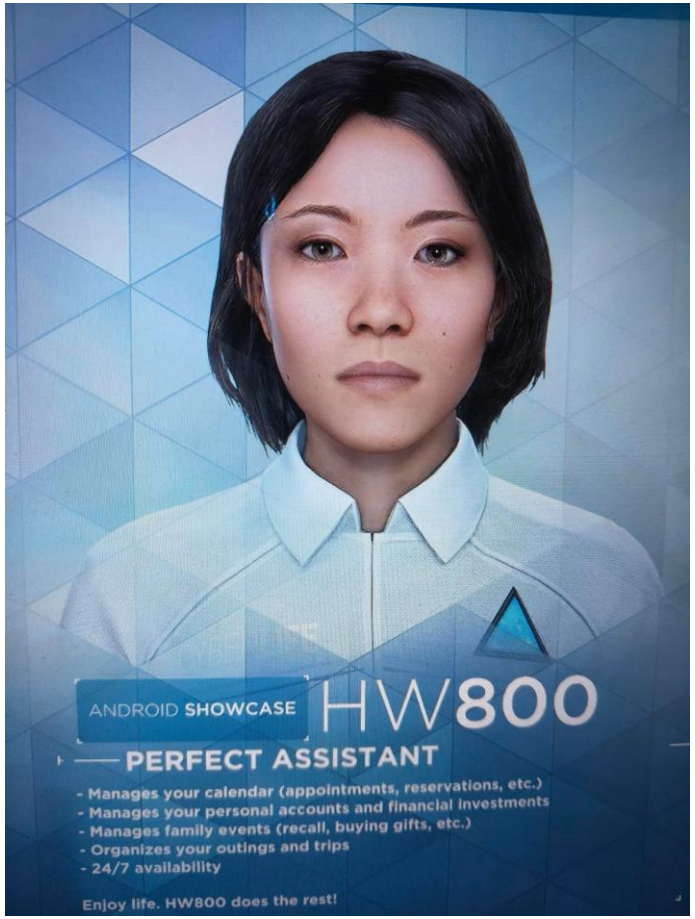
UNESCO's Network of AI Ethics Experts Without Borders (AIEB)

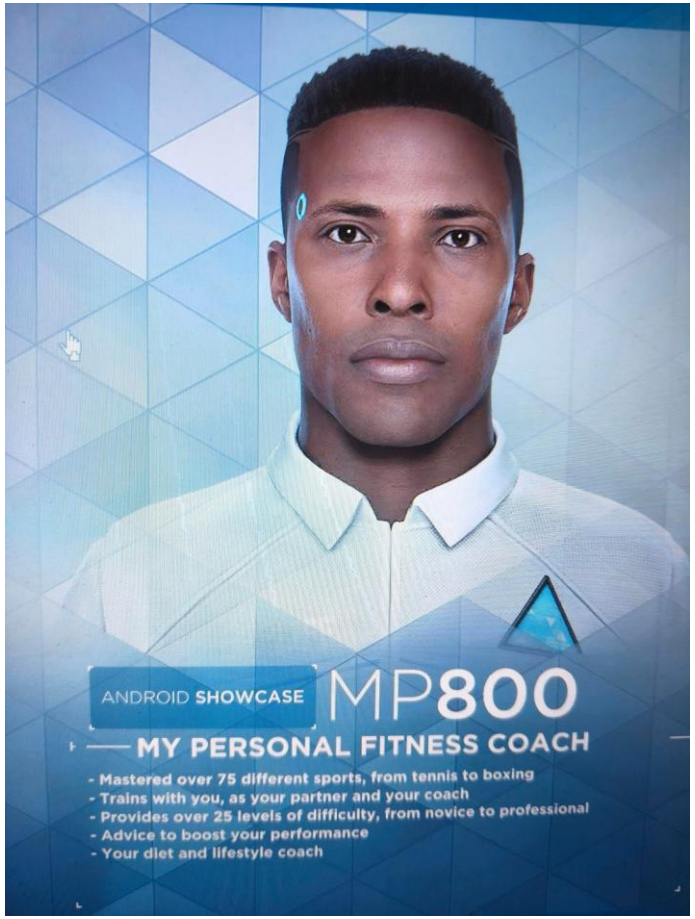
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A Thought Experiment: Detroit, 2038

In the video game "*Detroit: Become Human,*" AI-powered androids work across the economy







Source: Images: Detroit: Become Human (Quantic Dream, 2018), in-game screenshots and cover art

When Technology Outpaces Society



Technology advanced faster than society could adapt

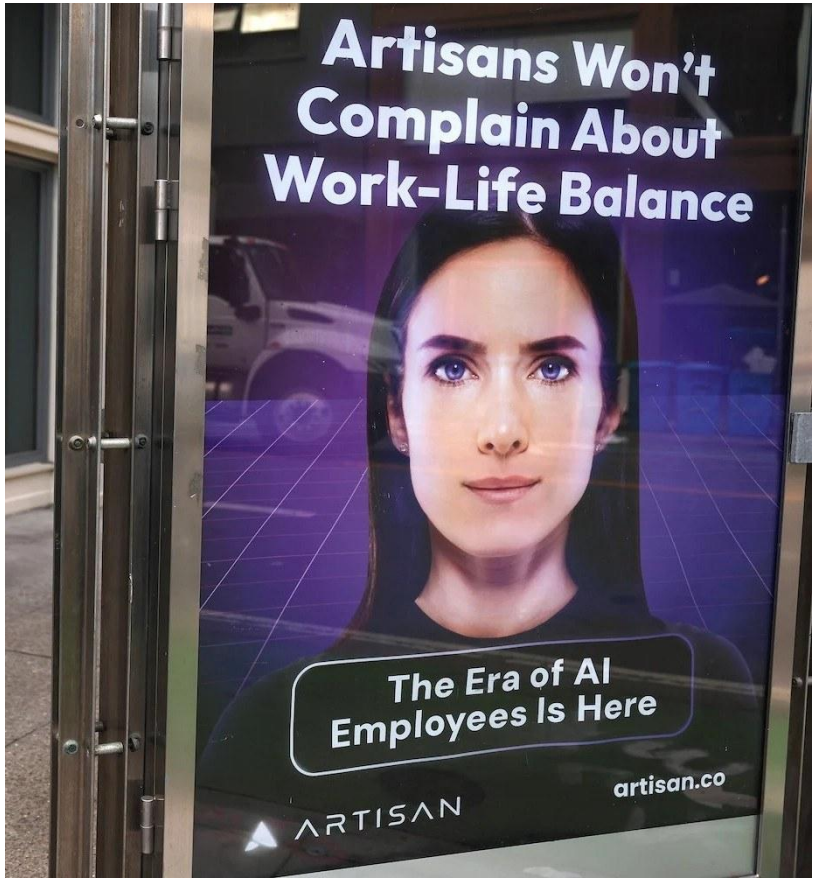


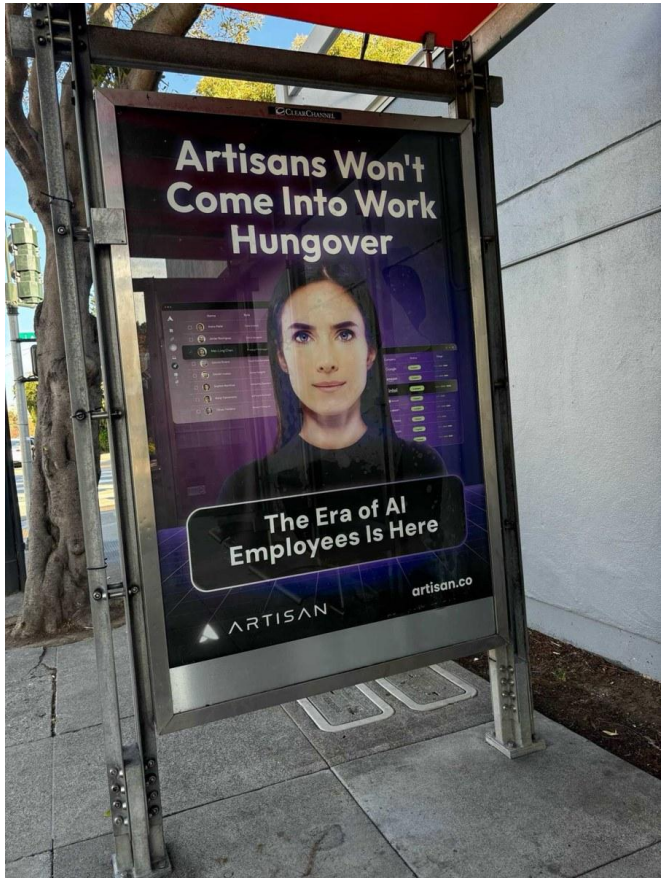


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Back to Reality: “Campaign: Stop Hiring Humans”







Advertising campaign by AI start-up Artisan in San Francisco, promoting a sales-automation tool

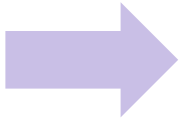
From Tool to Replacement?

The technology is far from androids, but the message is striking



AI as a tool

Something that helps humans do their work





AI as a replacement

An alternative to hiring humans

The forum's core question

In a world where AI can do almost anything, what does it mean to be human?

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Challenges

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Challenge 1: Job Displacement and Industry Disruptions

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9 million

jobs expected to be displaced globally by AI and information-processing technologies by 2030

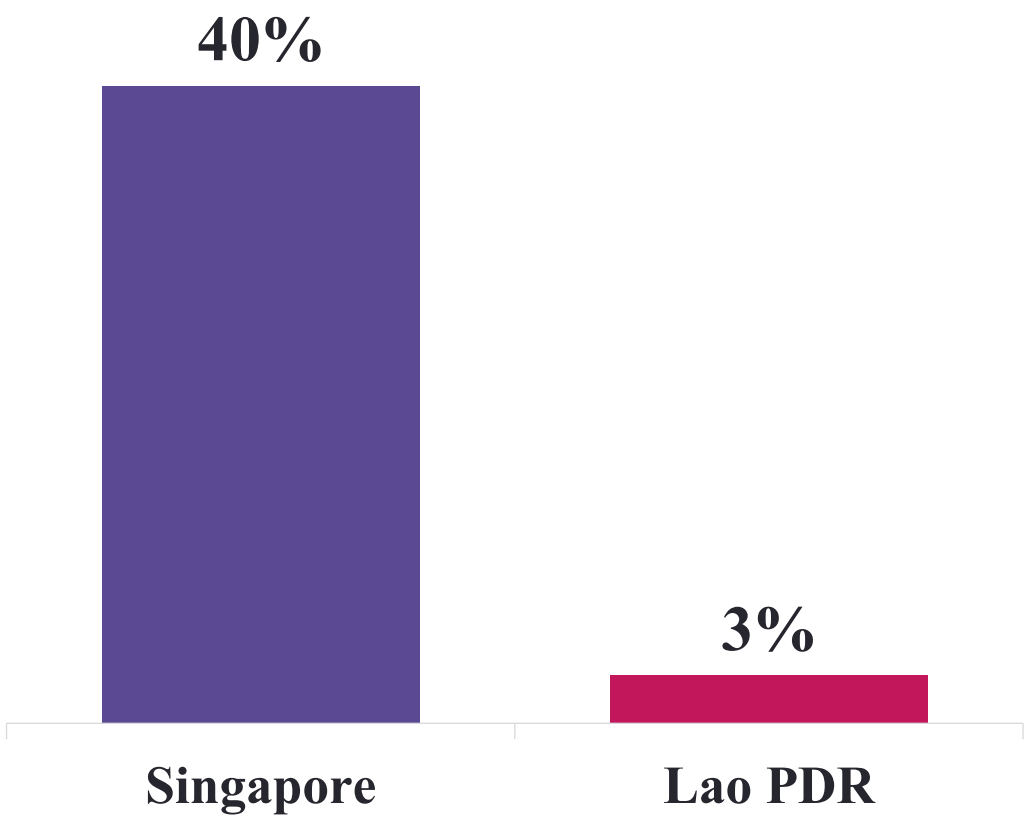
The real questions:

- Which industries and occupations will be affected?
- How quickly will the transformation happen?
- Can workers move into the new roles that emerge?

Source: World Economic Forum, Future of Jobs Report 2025

Challenge 2: The Global AI Divide

Share of jobs highly complementary to AI



Advanced economies

AI enhances workers, raises productivity and creates higher-value work

Developing economies

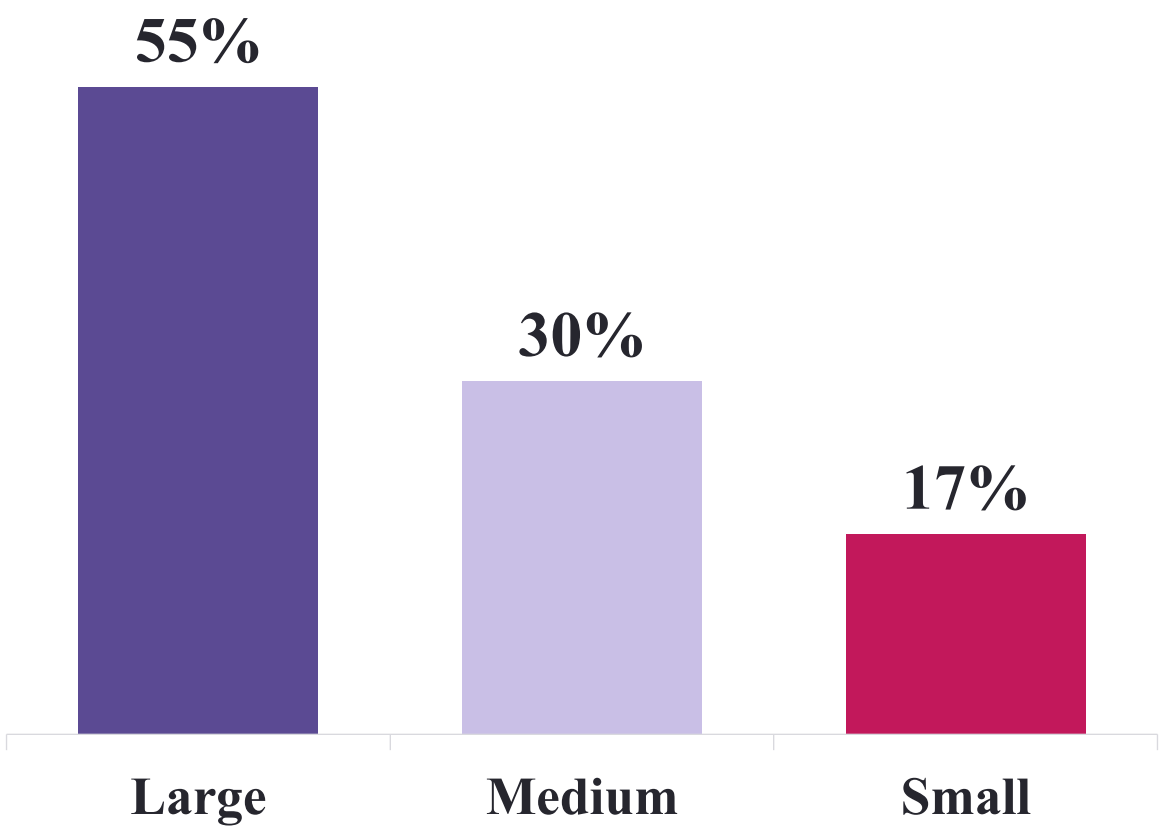
Risk of staying concentrated in lower-productivity activities

The divide is not only about who is at risk, but about who can benefit

Source: IMF, Regional Economic Outlook: Asia and Pacific (2024)

Challenge 3: Large Companies vs SMEs

EU enterprises using AI in 2025, by size



Source: Eurostat, Digitalisation in Europe – 2026 edition (2025 data)

≈ 2-3×

Large companies are almost 2-3 times as likely to use AI as SMEs

The risk

If SMEs cannot catch up, the productivity and competitiveness gap widens

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Opportunities

Opportunity 1: Increased Productivity and Efficiency

Workers can accomplish more in the same amount of time

+26%

more completed tasks for developers with access to an AI coding assistant

The study (2025)

- Nearly 4,900 software developers
- Microsoft, Accenture and a Fortune 100 company
- Field experiments giving access to an AI coding assistant

Source: Cui, Demirer, Jaffe, Musolff, Peng and Salz (2025), The Effects of Generative AI on High-Skilled Work: Evidence from Three Field Experiments with Software Developers

Opportunity 2: Economic Growth and Innovation

+15%

larger global economy by 2035 than expected, if AI matches past technological breakthroughs

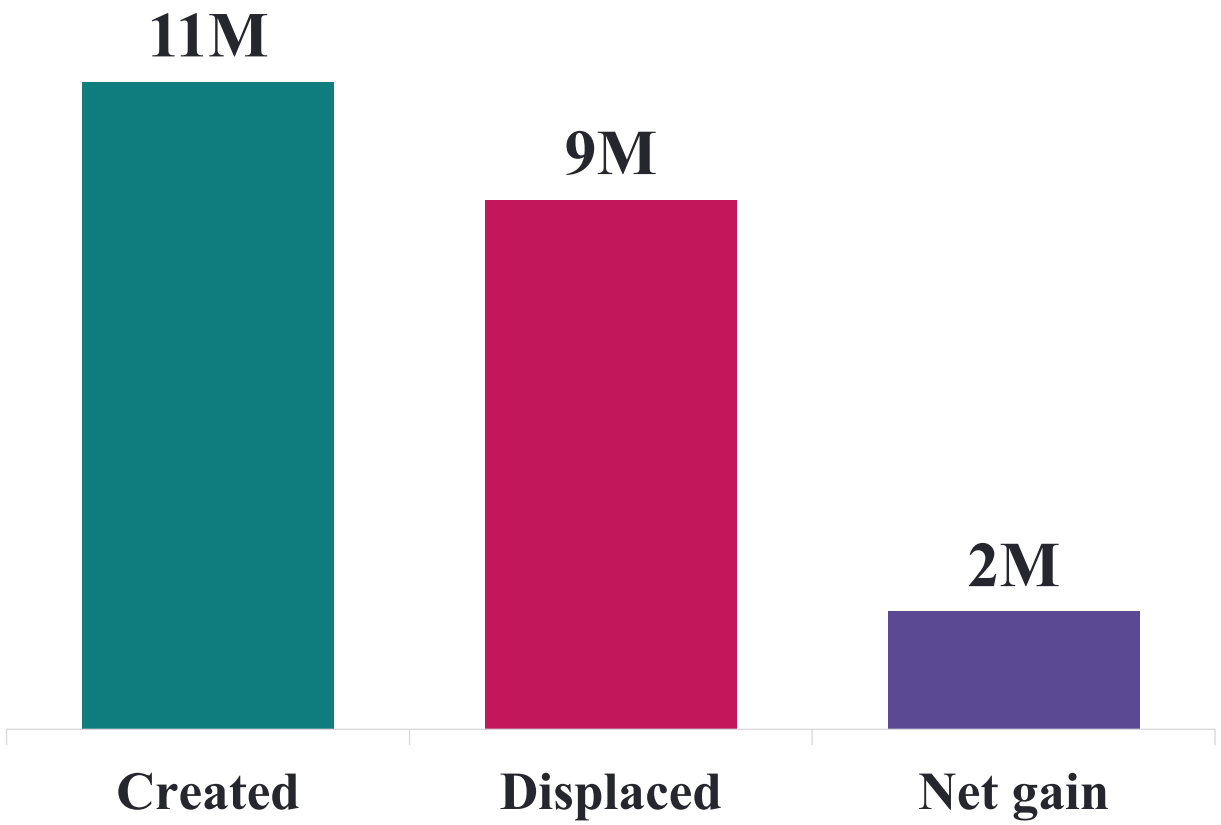
Where the growth could come from

- Higher productivity
- New AI-enabled products and services
- Industries reorganized around new sources of value

Source: PwC, Value in Motion (2025)

Opportunity 3: More Jobs Can be Created Than Displaced

Global jobs by 2030 (millions)



+2 million

net new jobs globally by 2030: more created than displaced

AI is also transforming existing roles

Source: World Economic Forum, Future of Jobs Report 2025 (AI and information-processing technologies)

The Real Challenge: Making the Smooth Transition

Jobs that are disappearing

Skills mismatch

Jobs that are emerging

Risk: structural unemployment, even if AI creates more jobs than it destroys

Can workers move from the jobs that are disappearing to the jobs that are emerging?

Five Policy Solutions for a Fair Transition



Better labour-market intelligence

General AI literacy for all

Lifelong learning and reskilling

Employer-led training

Social dialogue and worker voice

Goal: make the transition as painless and inclusive as possible

1. Start with Better Labour-Market Intelligence

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Before investing in training, know:

- Which occupations are evolving
- Which skills are growing or declining
- Where future gaps will emerge

Reactive → Proactive

Example: Jobs and Skills Australia

- Tracks real-time online job ads
- Maps skills to 1,100+ occupations
- Guides training and workforce planning

Source: Jobs and Skills Australia; Australian Skills Classification

2. Promote General AI Literacy Across the Workforce

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Not everyone needs to be an AI Engineer, but everyone needs to:

- **Understand AI**
- **Evaluate it critically**
- **Work with AI**
- **Know when to trust it**

Example: Estonia's AI Leap · secondary and vocational education

20,000	3,000	38,000	2,000
students	teachers	more students, incl. vocational	more teachers
Phase 1 · 2025	*Phase 1 · 2025*	*Phase 2 · 2026*	*Phase 2 · 2026*

Source: Estonian Ministry of Education and Research

3. Build Accessible Lifelong Learning Pathways

Flexible, affordable, short training, so people can learn while they work

Korea's AID 30+

Launched October 2024

For adults aged 30+

₩110 billion

(≈ US$80 million)

- Financial support (learning vouchers)
- Flexible university programmes
- Recognised academic credits
- Intensive evening and weekend courses
- Online learning

Source: Ministry of Education, Republic of Korea (October 2024)

4. Encourage Employer-Led Training

Governments can lower the cost and risk of training through:

- **Training subsidies**
- **Financial incentives**
- **Paid training leave**
- **Learning accounts**

Example: SkillsFuture Singapore

SkillsFuture Enterprise Credit funds employee training and business transformation, with extra support for SMEs

SMEs need targeted help

Subsidies, vouchers, shared training programmes and technical assistance

Source: SkillsFuture Singapore

5. Strengthen Social Dialogue and Worker Voice

AI adoption is not only a technological or managerial decision

Korea's Economic, Social and Labour Council (ESLC)

January 2025

AI and Labour Research Association

Studies how AI is changing the labour market

May 2026

Committee on Labor-Management Coexistence in the AI Transition

Labour, employers and government develop practical solutions

Workers consulted about new technologies tend to view AI's impact on their work more positively

Source: OECD, Artificial Intelligence and the Labour Market in Korea (2025)

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In Detroit, 2038, the technology was ready. Society was not.

AI will not decide whether the gap widens.

We will, through the choices we are going to make.

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Thank You

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